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The rise of data driven business models

In the early 2000's a new type of business currency came around, user data. (Business Money, 2024) stated that companies could target customers more successfully online by just using information as it was a lot more accessible and valuable. Many platforms including Google and Facebook started to use people's personalized data, which in turn led to major profit (RTE, 2025). This gave businesses a major advantage as it improved targeting. In December 2025, Meta stated that AI would be gradually rolled in to personalise content and ads for users (Meta, n.d.). Over the past few years, stricter regulations have been brought in around how data is shared and collected, there were uncertain laws surrounding this issue in the past (AC, 2025). Gradually companies began to understand that data had not only information value, but also financial value (Laarhoven-Smits, 2023).

Regulation and business transformation

In the past, the laws were not as strict and companies and businesses had more free will to do what they wanted with this data. After the GDPR came into place, businesses were forced to change the way they handled this data to meet compliance standards. This cost approximately 58% of businesses in Ireland between €50,000 and €250,000 to provide training and pay for relevant costs, which put financial pressure on them (McCannFitzgerald, 2018). Many of these businesses were required to add consent forms and hire data protection officers (GeeksForGeeks, 2025). In May 2023, Meta received a fine of 1.2 billion euros for breaching GDPR (Kramer, 2023), this caused a lot of backlashes towards the company and shows how non-compliance can negatively impact a brand's reputation. It became clear that it was important to take data protection into consideration for both a business strategy and social responsibility (IBM, n.d.). These laws created a demand for more roles like cybersecurity (GPDR Advisor, n.d.).

Privacy as a competitive advantage

Privacy is no longer considered only a legal requirement, but a way to build a business' reputation. The rising concern over user privacy has made businesses more aware of how important it is to be trustworthy with users' data as it is a key factor in competition (Goswami, 2020). Companies like Apple use privacy as part of their brand by attracting customers who care about security, which in turn leads to brand loyalty (UMATechnology, 2025). According to a Deloitte survey, 81% of customers reported that having trust in a company's data practices affects their decision of whether to purchase their product (Akomolafe, 2025). This highlights how important privacy is to customers. Acting responsibly with data helps keep customers loyal while also strengthening the company's brand image (Allen, 2024). Like a company's reputation of their products quality, their reputation of trust is equally as important.

Corporate Digital Responsibility and Ethics.

Corporate digital responsibility refers to certain practices and behaviors businesses use to ethically manage technology and data (CorporateDigitalResponsibility, n.d.). Businesses must inform users how their data is being stored. This is to prove they are transparent with the users and they should explain what information is being collected by using privacy statements, this is essential for building customer trust (EY, 2024). Companies must use AI ethically to ensure that artificial intelligence systems are fair to prevent ethical issues and maintain customer trust (IBM, n.d.). Strong cybersecurity measures must be put in place by businesses in order to protect customer data and prevent privacy issues (Legal Clarity, 2025). Many companies hire data protection officers to ensure compliance and responsible behavior to guarantee they follow the GDPR regulations (UCD, n.d.).

The Future Business Landscape

Over time businesses will move towards relying on technology to reduce manual labor for a faster and more effective workflow (bairesdev, 2025). As people continue to work from home, it is crucial for user data protection to be secured to protect them from data breaches and cyberattacks. Home systems are generally less secure which increases the risk of data exposure (GDPR Advisor, n.d.). Users are becoming more aware of how their data is being used so companies will have to ensure they have stronger governance practices otherwise businesses may lose customer trust (Riskrecon, 2025). As new privacy laws set into place, businesses will have to follow strict rules to ensure customer loyalty and protect their brand image.

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